Social Democracy: An Alternate History

Executive Game Overview

A plain-language guide to the current German baseline

Prepared from repository evidence and the local running game.
Audience: nontechnical project owner.
29 August 2026

Evidence boundary. This guide explains the game as implemented. It performs no external historical research and proposes no Polish equivalents. Uncertain behavior is labelled for code investigation or runtime testing.

Executive summary

Social Democracy: An Alternate History is a political strategy and interactive-fiction game. The player directs Germany's Social Democratic Party (SPD) from the beginning of 1928 through a period of elections, economic crisis, unstable governments, political violence, and possible democratic collapse. The game is less about commanding units on a map than about managing an organization under pressure. The player chooses messages, alliances, leaders, policies, and institutional responses, then watches those decisions change the political landscape over months and years.

The central rhythm is simple:

1. Return to a main screen that represents the party's current opportunities.
2. Draw an eligible action card from the Party Affairs or Government Affairs deck.
3. Play a card and choose how to respond.
4. Spend resources or accept political consequences.
5. Advance one month.
6. Resolve any event that has become due.
7. Recalculate support, factions, the economy, and later election results.

Under that straightforward loop is a highly connected simulation. A policy can please one SPD faction and anger another. A coalition can unlock ministries but also create coalition dissent. Economic policy can reduce unemployment while increasing inflation, spending, or resistance from business and conservative institutions. Party organizations can help defend democracy, but militancy can also make violent confrontation more likely. Elections reorganize the entire decision space because they change parliamentary strength, coalition options, government access, and cabinet control.

The game does not reduce success to a single score. Its ending system asks what survived, who controls the state, whether civil war occurred, whether the SPD remains in government, what economic program was achieved, and which special achievements were unlocked. Survival without an ideal outcome is possible; political or military defeat is also possible.

Four features are especially important for the project owner to understand:

- **Time is action-driven.** Most played cards spend the month's action. Time normally moves only after such an action resolves.
- **Visible percentages are produced from hidden preferences.** Cards usually change underlying support among social groups; the game normalizes those values into vote shares.
- **Government power is conditional.** Winning votes does not automatically grant every policy. Coalitions, ministries, relationships, the president, and institutional loyalty all matter.
- **Many systems share the same state.** A small change to one variable can affect card availability, elections, events, the interface, and endings.

For a Polish adaptation, the general turn structure is potentially separable from the German content, but the party model, electoral rules, institutions, organizations, dated events, leaders, and international framework cannot be carried across by changing names alone.

Contents

Reading conventions

Confirmed behavior is directly visible in **source/**, the compiled game, or the local running interface. **Interpretation** means the behavior is clear but its design intention is inferred. **Unclear** means the source or runtime does not establish a reliable answer without further testing.

The technical references are deliberately placed at the ends of sections and in the appendices. A reader can understand the main text without knowing JavaScript or DendryNexus.

1. The game from the player's perspective

What the game is about

The game places the player in charge of the SPD as a political organization, not in the role of one fixed historical person. The player manages party strategy across elections and governments while the game's version of the German Republic faces growing economic and political danger.

At the opening in January 1928, the SPD is in opposition. The status panel shows the current president and chancellor, the parliamentary shares of the major parties, the next election date, party resources, internal dissent, and basic economic indicators. The opening text describes a temporarily favorable moment and directs the player toward the next election. This is the game's own framing, confirmed in **source/scenes/root.scene.dry** and the local interface.

Who the player controls

The player controls the party's collective strategic choices. Examples include:

- how to campaign among different social groups;
- how high to set membership dues;
- which ideological message to emphasize;
- whether to cooperate with other parties;
- which advisers should form the active leadership team;
- whether to enter, support, or reject a coalition;
- which ministries to seek during government formation;
- which economic, fiscal, social, institutional, and foreign policies to pursue;
- how much to invest in political organizations and democratic defense;
- how to respond to crises and escalating political violence.

The player does not directly move the calendar or command every public event. Instead, the player acts through cards and choices. The simulation advances and reacts after those choices.

Primary goals

The source does not define one universal numeric victory score. The practical goals implied by the available choices and endings are to keep the SPD politically effective, preserve or reshape democratic government, prevent a hostile authoritarian takeover, manage economic collapse, and achieve selected party programs without triggering terminal political or military failure.

These goals can conflict. A radical policy may satisfy one faction and alienate another. A broad coalition may keep a government alive but restrict what the SPD can do. A costly response to unemployment may improve the economy but weaken the budget or provoke a capital strike. A strong defensive organization may improve resistance to violence while increasing the importance of militancy calculations.

Victory, survival, and defeat

The ending screen is a portfolio of outcomes rather than a single final grade. Confirmed ending checks include:

- whether Hitler or another Nazi leader controls the state;
- whether the republic won, lost, or remains trapped in civil war;
- whether the SPD still governs and who holds the presidency;
- whether a communist-led outcome occurred;
- whether unemployment was reduced;

- whether a works program, nationalization, stronger works councils, a

People's Party strategy, or European integration was achieved;

- which achievements were unlocked during this playthrough and across games.

“Victory” therefore means different things to different play styles. A player may survive without accomplishing every program, or achieve a policy goal while ending in a politically dangerous situation. The game-over logic is concentrated in **source/scenes/game_over.scene.dry**.

What the experience feels like

The tone is one of constrained choice. The player repeatedly chooses between valuable outcomes that draw on the same limited political capital. Information is imperfect: the interface summarizes some values in words, hides many raw timers and progress counters, and reveals consequences through later cards and events. Much of the tension comes from delayed effects rather than immediate failure messages.

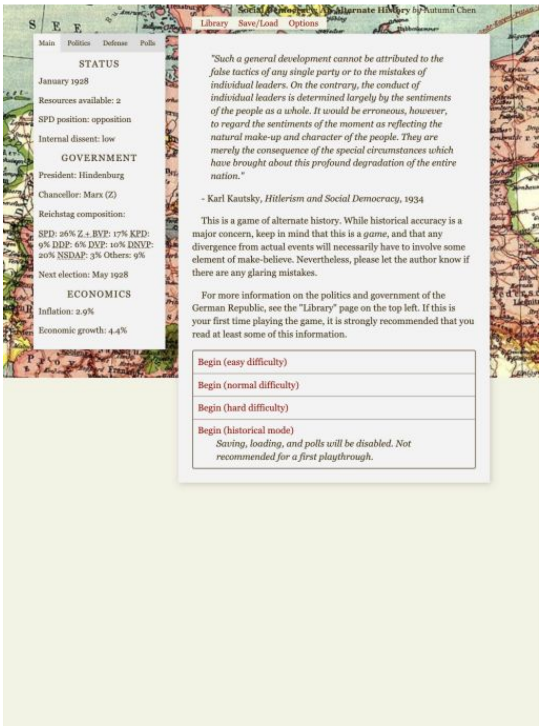


Figure 1. The local new-game screen combines the 1928 starting situation, current status, and four difficulty choices.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/root.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/status.scene.dry**, and **source/scenes/game_over.scene.dry**. Important state includes **started**, **year**, **month**, **resources**, **dissent**, **spd_in_government**, **president**, **chancellor**, and the ending/achievement flags.

2. Starting a new game and choosing difficulty

How a new game begins

The first menu offers Start game, Election simulation, Credits, and the achievement screen. Starting a game initializes a large shared record of the world: the date, party resources, factions, relationships, organizations, economic conditions, party preferences among social groups, parliamentary shares, office holders, event flags, advisers, and cooldown timers.

After initialization, the player chooses one of four modes:

Mode	Player-facing effect confirmed in source
Easy	More starting resources and dues, a stronger party-affiliated organization, friendlier relationships, a larger government budget, four hand slots, and an easy discard route.
Normal	The baseline initial values and three hand slots.
Hard	Fewer resources and dues, more faction dissent, weaker relationships, a smaller budget, and a weaker starting organization.
Historical	Harder initial political/fiscal conditions, saving and polls disabled, and two party resources added at each year rollover.

Difficulty changes more than prices. It alters the starting political situation and, in easy/historical modes, changes available interface or hand behavior. That makes it a combined rules-and-scenario setting rather than a simple numeric multiplier.

What happens after selection

All modes route into the 1928 introduction and then the main hand. Normal, hard, and historical modes use a hand limit of three cards. Easy uses four. The Government Affairs deck is initially hidden and becomes available after the internal time counter reaches six, so the early game focuses on the party before opening the government-action layer.

Difficulty-related uncertainty

The source establishes the changed initial values, but the interface does not list all of them before the player chooses. A first-time player can understand that hard is harder, but cannot see exactly which relationships and faction values were changed. A future design should decide how transparent these hidden modifiers should be.

Technical reference: difficulty subscenes in **source/scenes/root.scene.dry**; hand limits and the government-deck gate in **source/scenes/main.scene.dry**. Important state: **difficulty**, **historical_mode**, **resources**, **dues**, **budget**, **rb_strength**, party relationships, faction dissent, and **time**.

3. The normal gameplay loop

What the main screen represents

The main screen is not a geographic map of orders. It is the party's current agenda. It has three functional zones:

- **Decks** contain categories of actions. Party Affairs is present from the

start; Government Affairs appears later and is useful when government access exists.

- **Hand** contains the specific action cards already drawn. Drawing creates

options; playing one begins the decision.

- **Pinned cards** remain available outside the normal draw/discard cycle.

These are primarily advisers and leadership management.

The left status panel remains visible. It shows enough context to judge a choice: date, resources, government position, parliament, economic conditions, relationships, factions, or security organizations depending on the selected tab.

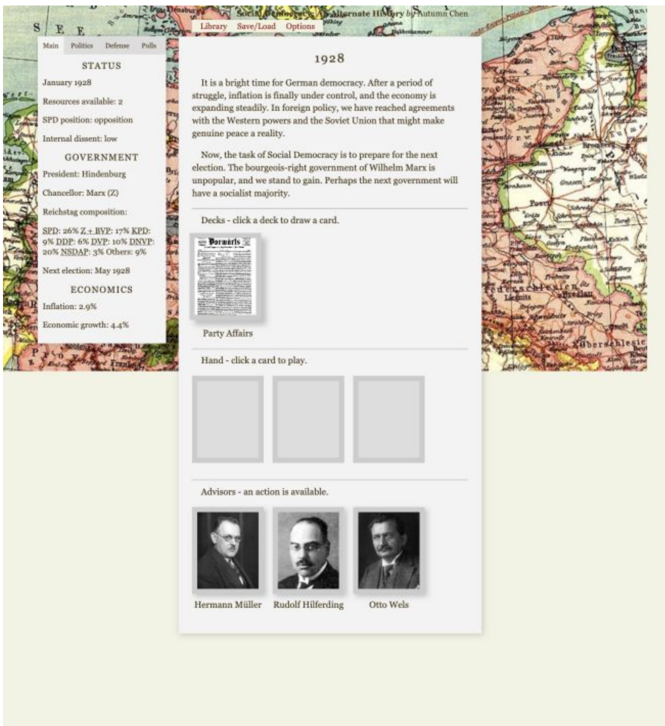
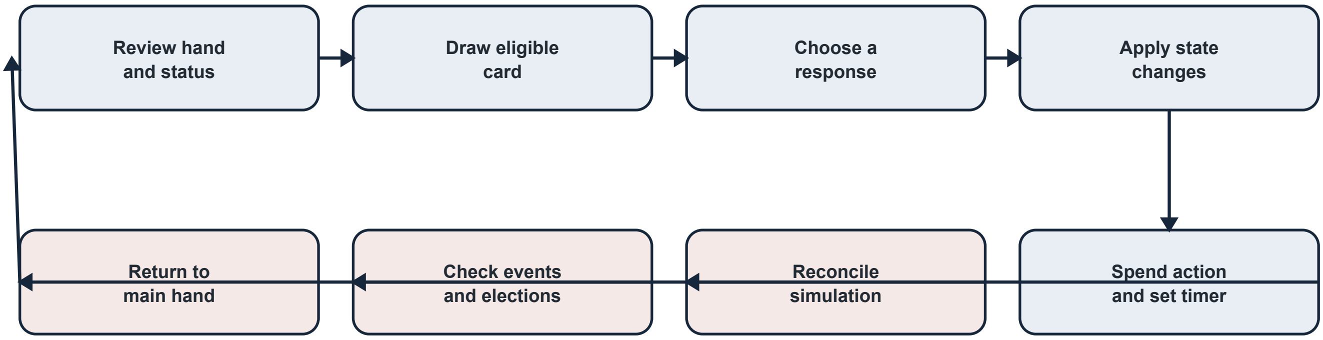


Figure 2. The local main hand: one Party Affairs deck, three empty hand slots, and three pinned advisers at the beginning of normal mode.

Step-by-step turn

1. **Review the situation.** Check the status tabs, current resources, election timing, faction mood, and any urgent problem.
2. **Draw a card.** Click a deck. Dendry filters its cards to those whose conditions are currently satisfied, then draws an eligible card into the hand.
3. **Choose whether to play it.** The card remains in the hand until selected. Normal mode expects the player to commit; easy mode provides more forgiving discard/cancel behavior.

4. **Read the card and choose an option.** The card explains the situation and usually presents several approaches. Some choices are hidden or disabled if the party lacks money, office, support, or another prerequisite.
5. **Apply consequences.** The selected option changes shared game state. It may spend resources, adjust support, alter faction dissent, change a relationship, advance a policy, or set an event flag.
6. **Spend the month.** Most normal action cards mark that one monthly action has been used and start a cooldown.
7. **Reconcile the simulation.** The game recalculates party support and faction totals. If an action was spent, it advances the date by one month, reduces active cooldowns, records chart data, and updates the economy.
8. **Resolve an event if due.** Dated and conditional events are checked. An eligible event can interrupt the return to the main hand.
9. **Return to the hand.** After event resolution, the next cycle begins with the changed status visible.



Important qualification

The main loop is confirmed, but simultaneous event selection and exact random draw guarantees are not fully explained by player-facing text. If multiple events are eligible at once, their priority and Dendry choice behavior need targeted runtime tests.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/main.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/return.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/easy_discard.scene.dry**, and **source/scenes/cancel_advisor_action.scene.dry**. Important state: **month_actions**, **time**, **year**, **month**, **timers**, and all ***_timer** values.

4. A concrete turn, event, and month

Example A: playing a normal Fundraising card

Fundraising is a clear example because it connects actions, resources, membership dues, faction mood, public support, and time.

At the beginning of normal mode, the party has 2 resources and dues of 2. If the Fundraising card is eligible and drawn:

1. Opening the card starts a six-month fundraising cooldown and marks the monthly action as spent.
2. **Maintain dues** adds resources equal to current dues. At the default start, that means gaining 2 resources.
3. **Reduce dues** first lowers dues by one, then adds the new dues amount to resources. It also reduces dissent in four factions. At the default start, dues become 1 and the party gains 1 resource.
4. **Increase dues** raises dues by one and adds the new amount to resources, but lowers SPD support among workers and unemployed people. The penalty is worse under high unemployment and when dues are already high.

This is a typical design pattern: the player is not choosing “good” versus “bad.” The player chooses which problem to accept. Higher dues fund future actions but can damage the electoral base. Lower dues soothe the party but produce less money.

The card is unavailable in historical mode and while its cooldown is positive. That is an example of a hidden rule shaping the visible card pool.

Example B: resolving Black Thursday

The event named Black Thursday becomes eligible when the game reaches 1929 and the month is October or later. It has a one-visit limit. On arrival, it marks itself as seen and changes several parts of the simulation at once:

- support shifts among workers, middle-class, rural, and unemployed groups;
- unemployment rises;

- the government budget can fall;
- dues can fall;
- inflation and economic growth decline.

The player then chooses either a general interpretation of the crisis or a commitment to address suffering. The latter raises **crisis_urgency**, which affects the later economic-policy debate. The event therefore does more than tell a story: it changes future card conditions and policy pressure.

Example C: advancing one month

After Fundraising or another normal action marks **month_actions** as at least one, the reconciliation scene:

1. recalculates demographic support and overall party vote shares;
2. normalizes faction strengths and recalculates overall dissent;
3. adds one to the internal month counter;
4. advances the calendar month, rolling December into January of the next year;
5. resets **month_actions** to zero;
6. reduces every active timer whose base name is listed in the central timer array;
7. appends support and economic values to the chart history;
8. applies monthly economic feedback;
9. checks the event pool before returning to the hand.

The action, not the act of drawing, ends the month. Merely drawing a card does not advance time.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/party_affairs/fundraising.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/events/black_thursday.scene.dry**, and **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**. Important state: **resources**, **dues**, **fundraising_timer**, **month_actions**, **crisis_urgency**, **unemployed**, **inflation**, **economic_growth**, **budget**, and demographic support values.

5. Time and events

Three ways of describing time

The game maintains:

- **year**, the displayed year;
- **month**, a number from 1 to 12 translated into a month name by a qdisplay;
- **time**, a simple elapsed-month counter used by some availability conditions.

These values normally move together. A completed monthly action advances **time** and **month**; month 13 becomes January and adds one to **year**.

Scheduled events

A scheduled event has a condition based on the date. Black Thursday checks for 1929 and October or later. Annual scenes react to particular years. Elections compare the current date with the next election date. A one-visit limit or a seen flag prevents repeated presentation.

Conditional events

A conditional event responds to state rather than only the calendar. Examples include escalation of coup progress, capital-strike progress, coalition dissent, economic stress, party-faction dissent, or the success/failure of an earlier choice. Many important events combine date and state conditions.

Random, scheduled, and player-triggered content

These labels describe different sources of uncertainty:

- **Random card draw:** deck cards are drawn from the currently eligible tagged set. This is the clearest confirmed use of randomness in ordinary play.
- **Scheduled event:** a date makes a tagged event eligible after the month's action.
- **Conditional event:** a threshold or flag makes an event eligible.
- **Player-triggered event:** not a separate Dendry object type. It is an event whose eligibility was caused by earlier player choices, such as increasing a crisis or coup counter.

It is **unclear** whether simultaneous eligible events are always ordered by priority, presented as a player choice, or randomly selected in every case. That requires focused runtime testing.

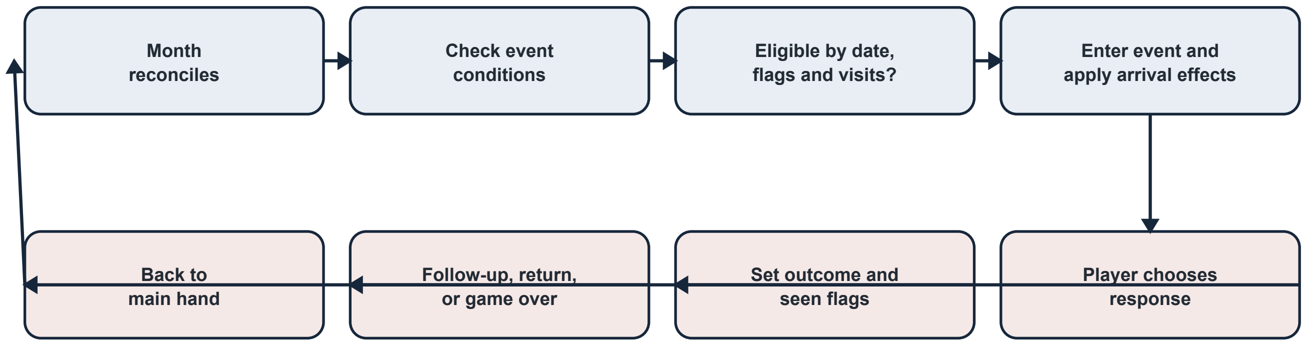
Elections and major crises

Elections interrupt the ordinary loop with a larger sequence: recalculate vote shares, apply thresholds and bans, produce parliamentary shares, show results, calculate possible coalitions, choose a government path, negotiate ministries, and schedule the next election.

Major crises can similarly branch into multi-scene sequences. They may change the action economy, remove government options, force institutional decisions, or route toward terminal conflict. The source treats them as connected scenes, not as a separate "crisis engine."

Event flags

Flags are memory. A value such as **black_thursday_seen** tells later scenes that the event occurred. Some flags prevent repeats; some unlock follow-ups; some record the outcome chosen. Timers can delay follow-up content, and visit counts provide a second repetition control.



Technical reference: **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**, all files under **source/scenes/events/**, and event tags/conditions in compiled **out/game.json**. Important state: **year**, **month**, **time**, **has_event**, ***_seen**, ***_timer**, next-election fields, threshold counters, and scene visit counts maintained by Dendry.

6. Cards, decks, hands, actions, and resources

Cards, decks, and hands

The best analogy is a desk with two filing trays. A deck is a category of possible work; a card is one specific issue drawn from that category; the hand is the small set of issues currently on the desk.

The Party Affairs deck contains campaigning, fundraising, ideology, media, organization, relationships, rallies, leadership, and similar party work. The Government Affairs deck contains policy and ministerial work and appears after the early-game time gate. A card can also be hidden by its own requirements, including cooldown, government position, ministry ownership, date, resources, or earlier choices.

Pinned cards do not behave like ordinary drawn cards. Advisers and leadership management remain visible because they represent persistent people or controls, not a transient agenda item.

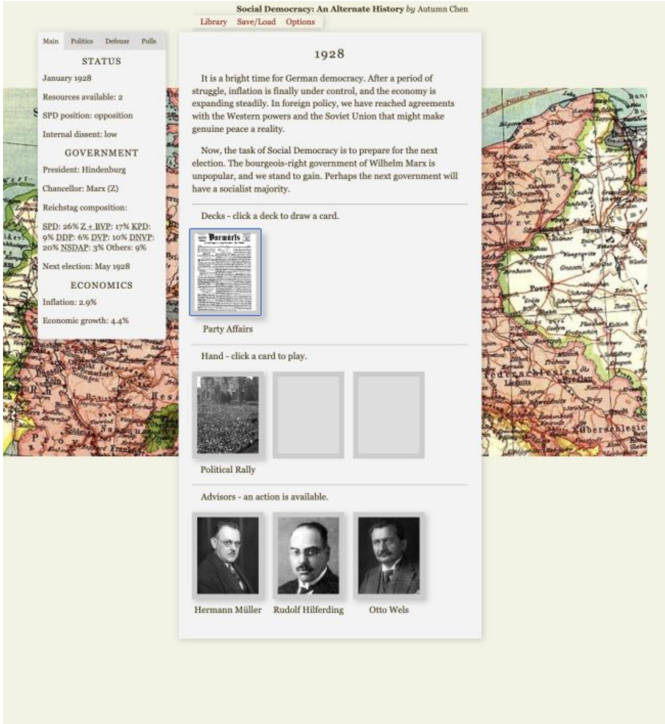


Figure 3. A Party Affairs draw places Political Rally into the hand while the advisers remain pinned below it.

Action economy

Most normal action cards add one to **month_actions** when opened or resolved. The reconciliation scene sees that marker and advances one month. The game therefore gives the player approximately one major party/government action per month, plus access to pinned adviser actions subject to their own shared cooldown.

Easy-mode return/cancel routes can reverse the action marker, clear the matching timer, reset a card's visit count, and return it to the hand. This is a special convenience, not the normal rule.

Party resources and government budget

The game has two distinct financial abstractions:

- **Resources** belong to the party and pay for campaigning, media,

organizations, advisers, and political activity.

- **Budget** belongs to the government and constrains policy. A negative budget

is allowed, but monthly logic turns deficits into inflation pressure and some political/economic consequences.

Membership **dues** help generate party resources through Fundraising. They are not the same as taxes, and resources are not the government budget.

What improves or damages this mechanic

Fundraising, difficulty settings, annual historical-mode income, and some events increase or protect resources. Expensive actions reduce them. Government revenue/spending choices affect budget. A weak resource position reduces the party's capacity to solve problems, while a weak budget restricts government policy and can worsen economic feedback.

Failure and uncertainty

There is no confirmed universal "bankruptcy" ending for party resources. Instead, insufficient resources hide or disable choices. Budget can become negative. Exact balance targets for how often cards should be affordable are not stated in source.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/main.scene.dry**, party/government card files, **source/scenes/party_affairs/fundraising.scene.dry**, and **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**. Important state: **resources**, **dues**, **budget**, **month_actions**, **advisor_action_timer**, and card-specific timers.

7. Support, elections, parliament, and coalitions

Party support and vote share

The game does not normally add “one percentage point” directly to a national poll. It stores hidden preference weights for combinations such as workers-SPD or rural-NSDAP. Cards and events change these raw weights. At reconciliation, the game performs two normalizations:

1. Within each social group, it converts all party weights into percentages.
2. It weights those group percentages by the group's size and converts the result into national party shares.

The six starting groups are workers, old middle class, new middle class, rural, unemployed, and Catholics. The starting party list has eight categories; a later splinter party can be added dynamically.

This design makes political effects indirect. A card that improves SPD appeal among workers may have a large national effect because workers have a large weight. The same raw change among a smaller group may matter less. Overall SPD dissent can reduce positive support gains in many scenes.

Failure conditions: each social group's preference total must remain above zero for normalization to work. The source clamps negative preferences to zero but does not visibly guard every possible zero denominator.

Elections and parliamentary shares

At an election, the game recalculates support, then applies the current electoral threshold and party bans. Parties that fail the rule receive zero parliamentary share; qualifying results are normalized again. The game stores the previous result, calculates the change, finds the largest party, and saves the result for charts.

The parliamentary display uses percentages as an approximate seat share. The D3 semicircle multiplies shares into roughly 500 colored positions. The source contains a **use_decimals** TODO, and there is no confirmed district-level or remainder-seat allocator. The graphic is therefore a useful overview, not evidence of a fully exact seat model.

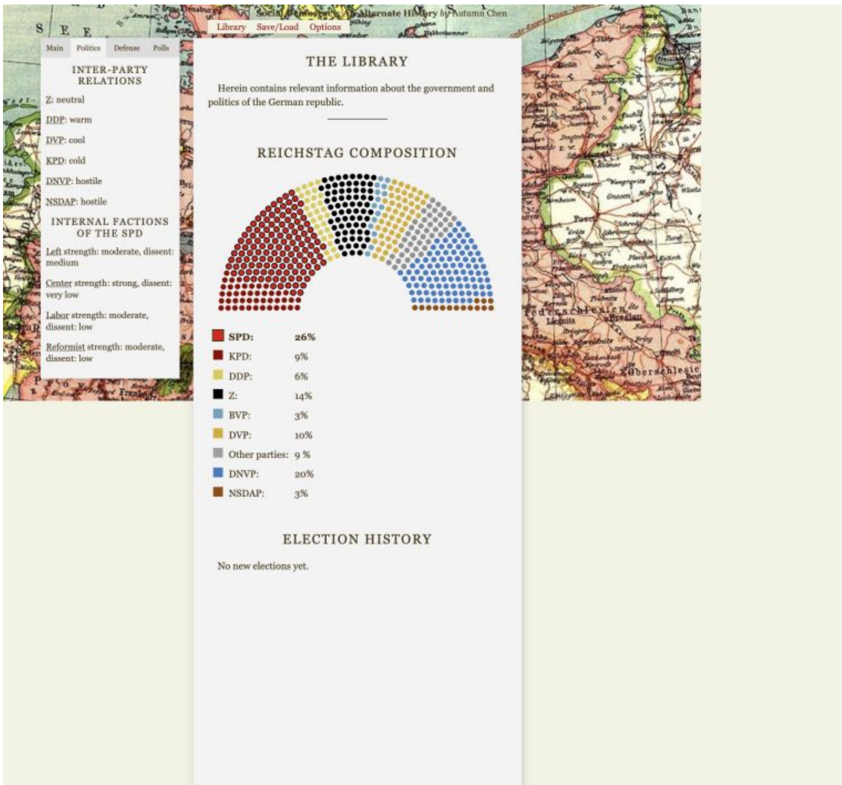


Figure 4. The local Library renders the starting Reichstag as an approximate semicircle and provides space for election, support, and economic history.

Coalition formation

Election code adds party shares into named coalition totals. The player then sees routes that can depend on:

- whether the combination reaches a majority;
- relations with partner parties;
- available resources or leverage;
- party leadership;

- presidential and constitutional conditions;
- earlier failed negotiations.

Entering a coalition sets government flags, appoints a chancellor, assigns initial ministries, and opens a ministry negotiation. Parliamentary strength produces **leverage**, which the player spends to claim offices.

Coalition dissent

Coalition dissent represents conflict among governing partners. Policy choices can raise it; coalition-management actions can address it. The interface summarizes it from very low through very high. High dissent can contribute to coalition crises or confidence votes.

The government is represented by many separate flags rather than one single government object. That creates a risk: incomplete resets can leave contradictory states. The intended mutual exclusivity of every coalition flag requires route testing.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/election_algorithm.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/events/election_1928.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/government_affairs/coalition_affairs.scene.dry**, and **source/scenes/library.scene.dry**. Important state includes the dynamic class-party families, party **_normalized**, **_votes**, and **_r** families, **electoral_threshold**, party bans, coalition totals, **coalition_dissent**, government flags, **leverage**, and ministry-party fields.

8. Factions, relationships, advisers, and government

Internal party factions

The SPD contains five modeled factions: Left, Center, Labor, Reformist, and Neorevisionist. Each has a strength and a dissent value. Cards, advisers, leadership decisions, coalition choices, and policies move those values.

After each action, faction strengths are normalized so they add to 100. Overall party dissent is a weighted result: anger in a strong faction matters more than the same anger in a weak faction. Individual dissent is kept between 0 and 99; overall dissent is capped below complete disunity.

Faction dissent matters because it reduces the benefit of some support gains and can unlock party-disunity content. Several resignation or split events use 60 as an important faction-dissent threshold. This is a feedback loop: a policy choice produces faction anger; anger weakens electoral gains; weaker results reduce government options; constrained government can cause more anger.

Relationships with other parties

Separate numeric values record relations with the Center Party, KPD, DDP, DVP, DNVP, and NSDAP. The player sees labels such as hostile, cold, neutral, warm, or friendly rather than the raw number. Coalition and presidential-election routes use their own numeric thresholds.

This means a seemingly symbolic relationship card can change a future coalition or candidate negotiation. The source contains a case-sensitive initialization inconsistency for DNVP and NSDAP relations, so those two values require runtime verification.

Advisers and leadership

The player begins with three pinned advisers. The broader adviser library contains people associated with factions or specialist roles. Leadership management adds or removes advisers and can change faction strength/dissent.

Adviser actions generally use a shared cooldown. They can shortcut or modify other systems: campaign support, faction management, organizations, institutional policy, or government work. Because they are pinned, advisers feel like strategic capabilities rather than random issues.

Cabinet positions and ministries

Government entry does not grant every policy automatically. The player can spend election-derived leverage on ministries such as Labor, Interior, Finance, Economic, Justice, Foreign, Agriculture, and Reichswehr. Ministry-party fields gate government cards; named minister fields support the narrative; goal fields track office-specific tasks.

Coalition bargains, office ownership, named ministers, and goals are stored separately. A government redesign therefore has to update all four layers.

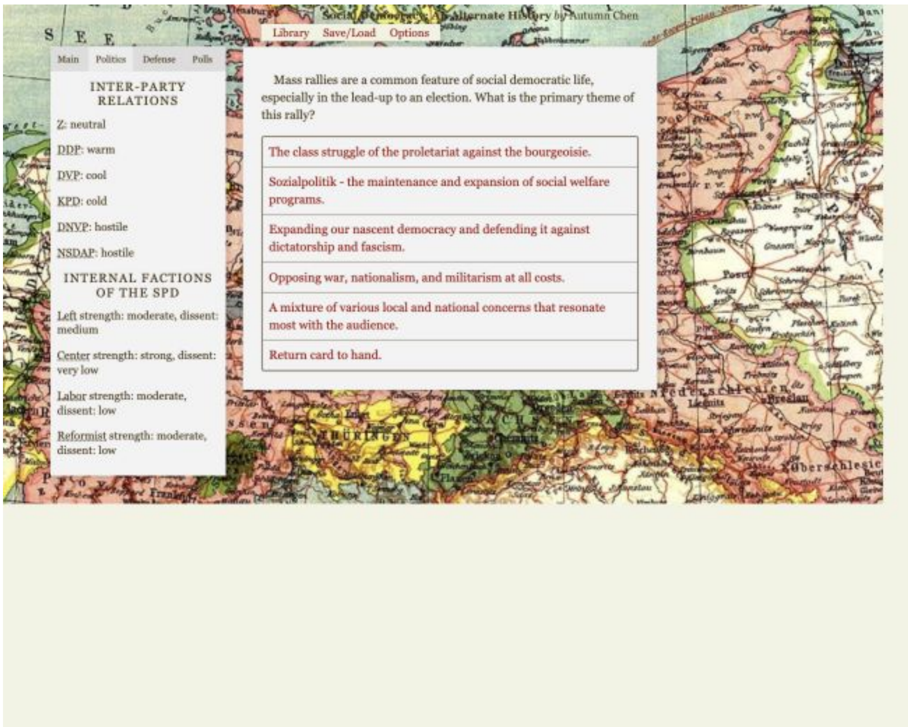


Figure 5. The Politics tab translates raw relationships and faction numbers into readable labels while a card choice remains in the center.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/party_affairs/party_disunity.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/party_affairs/inter_party_relationships.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/party_affairs/shuffle_leadership.scene.dry**, adviser files under **source/scenes/advisors/**, and ministry sections of **source/scenes/events/election_1928.scene.dry**. Important state: faction strength/dissent, **dissent**, party relations, adviser flags, **advisor_action_timer**, **leverage**, ministry ownership, and government flags.

9. Economy, finance, organizations, and institutions

Economic conditions and policy

The visible economic indicators are inflation, unemployment after the crash, and economic growth. The game also stores the government budget and several policy-program stages.

Annual and crisis events alter the baseline economy. Monthly reconciliation adds feedback: deficits can increase inflation; works programs can alter later unemployment and growth; crisis choices change pressure for action. The player can debate and adopt broad economic plans, then use government cards to implement them in stages.

The plan codes distinguish no plan, a WTB/public-works direction, a moderate plan, and a nationalization direction. Each route has its own support, adoption, progress, budget, and political consequences. Strong intervention can advance capital-strike or coup pressure.

Taxation and government finance

Upper tax rates, lower tax rates, and tariffs are signed policy levels. A qdisplay turns them into phrases from extremely low through extremely high. Fiscal choices influence budget and also affect parties, classes, growth, unemployment, inflation, or business resistance.

The budget is simultaneously a permission to spend and an input into monthly economic feedback. This makes it tightly coupled and difficult to rebalance in isolation.

Political organizations

Party Affairs cards support campaigning, media, cultural organizations, rallies, party organization, the Reichsbanner, and the Iron Front. These actions spend party resources and change support, organization strength, militancy, faction mood, or later event flags.

The source uses different kinds of “strength” values. Some are described as thousands of members; others are abstract. The interface's strength qdisplay uses common labels despite those differences. A future design should define units before rebalancing.

Militancy and political violence

The game tracks the Reichsbanner, Stahlhelm, SA, and RFB with separate strength, militancy, and ban state. Conflict scenes derive power by combining these values. Political choices can strengthen, restrain, militarize, ban, or persecute organizations.

Violence is connected to party strategy and institutions rather than being a separate combat minigame. When escalation reaches a crisis, the game compares friendly and hostile forces and routes toward coup or civil-war outcomes.

Police and institutional loyalty

The game separately tracks Prussian police, interior police, and the Reichswehr. Strength, militancy, loyalty, training, investigation, and reform choices influence whether institutions protect or threaten the government.

Constitutional policy adds another institutional layer: electoral threshold, party bans, constructive vote of no confidence, and presidential powers can change election and government routes.

Important failure thresholds include coup and capital-strike progress at 10. The precise combined power formulas and mixed units should be treated as high-risk implementation details.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/post_event.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/party_affairs/crisis_program.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/government_affairs/economic_policy.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/government_affairs/fiscal_policy.scene.dry**, organization and street-fighting cards under **source/scenes/party_affairs/**, institutional cards under **source/scenes/government_affairs/**, and **source/scenes/events/civil_war.scene.dry**. Important state: **unemployed**, **inflation**, **economic_growth**, **budget**, economic-plan families, tax/tariff levels, organization strength/militancy, institutional loyalty, derived power, **capital_strike_progress**, and **coup_progress**.

10. International relations, achievements, endings, and saves

International relations

International policy appears at both party and government levels. The source tracks relations and aid associated with western, eastern, Soviet, and Austrian directions, along with reparations, war-guilt policy, customs-union choices, and European-integration progress.

These are not a single “foreign relations score.” Separate directions allow a choice to improve one relationship while harming another, and domestic factions or coalition partners can respond. Dated international events also read these choices.

The entire actor list, agreement structure, dates, and domestic consequences are specific to the current German baseline.

Achievements and endings

Achievements exist at two levels: current-play fields and persistent unlocks. The game-over scene evaluates political, economic, institutional, coalition, and personal-leadership outcomes. It then presents eligible ending summaries and unlocked achievements.

Because many ending conditions can be true at once, the ending screen is a collection of consequences. The exact ordering when multiple tagged endings are eligible needs a targeted terminal-state test.

Saving and loading

The customized browser interface provides two autosave slots, eight manual slots, load/delete/export controls, and save-file import. Saves are stored in browser storage through the Dendry runtime. Historical mode disables saving.

State-variable names are therefore part of the save format. Renaming a quality can break old saves even when the new code builds successfully.

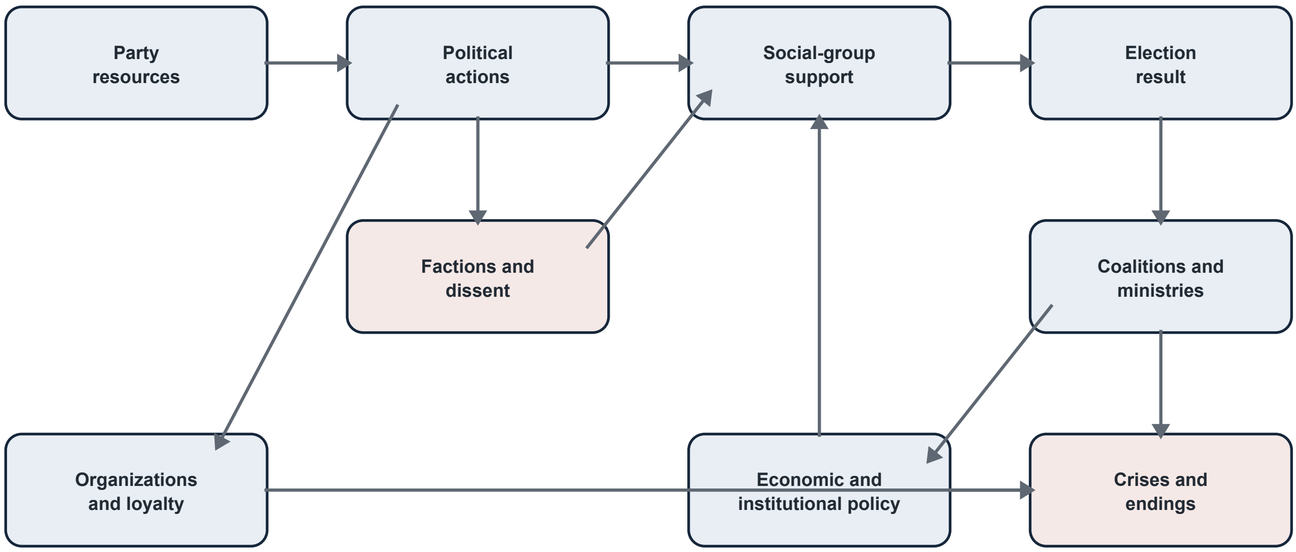
Mod support

The browser runtime includes a mod loader that can load alternate game data by URL and refers to a curated remote table. The source establishes the presence of this feature, but network access, trust boundaries, CORS behavior, malformed data handling, and compatibility guarantees were not tested for this guide.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/party_affairs/international_relations.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/government_affairs/foreign_policy.scene.dry**, international event scenes, **source/scenes/game_over.scene.dry**, **source/scenes/mod_loader.scene.dry**, and customized runtime file **out/html/game.js**.

11. How the systems interact

No major mechanic is truly isolated. The diagram below shows the most important direction of influence, not every connection.



Important feedback loops

Resource-pressure loop

Low resources hide useful party actions. With fewer campaign, media, or organization choices, the party may struggle to improve support or respond to threats. Weak results then reduce government leverage and access to tools that could relieve the pressure.

Faction-support loop

A policy angers a strong faction. Weighted overall dissent rises. Many positive support gains are reduced by dissent. Weaker electoral support narrows coalition options, and an unattractive coalition can create further faction anger.

Coalition-survival loop

A coalition grants ministries and the ability to enact policy. Controversial policy raises coalition dissent. High dissent creates disputes or confidence votes. Loss of government removes access to the ministries needed to continue or repair the program.

Economic-crisis loop

The economy worsens, changing social-group preferences and increasing pressure for action. Intervention spends budget and can trigger inflation or resistance. A weak budget creates additional monthly inflation pressure. Political reaction can then reduce support or coalition stability.

Violence-institution loop

Threatening organizations grow or become more militant. The player invests in defensive organizations and seeks loyal police or military institutions. Institutional reform may provoke conservative resistance or coup progress. Those risks make further defensive investment more urgent.

Why advisers and ministries matter across systems

Advisers are persistent shortcuts or modifiers; ministries are access keys. Together they determine not only what a policy does, but whether the player can attempt it at all. Elections change coalition possibilities; coalitions change ministry ownership; ministries change the card pool; the card pool changes the next election. This is the game's broadest strategic cycle.

12. Interface and information

What the interface shows

The persistent left panel is divided into tabs:

- **Main:** date, resources, SPD government position, overall dissent,

president, chancellor, parliament, next election, budget when relevant, and headline economic indicators.

- **Politics:** relationships with other parties and SPD faction

strength/dissent.

- **Defense:** organization strength/militancy and police/military loyalty.
- **Polls:** projected vote shares and detailed social-group results, except

when historical mode hides polling.

The top links open the Library, Save/Load, and Options. The center panel contains the current narrative, hand, card, event, government negotiation, or reference page.

What qdisplays are

A qdisplay is a translation table. It turns a raw number into words. For example, a relationship number becomes hostile, cold, neutral, warm, friendly, or very friendly. Other qdisplays cover month names, dissent, coalition dissent, strength, militancy, loyalty, and taxation.

This reduces cognitive load but hides exact thresholds. A relationship can change without its label changing, and then unexpectedly cross a coalition gate. The label used by a qdisplay is also not necessarily the same threshold used by a particular choice.

How cards communicate availability

Cards can be completely absent because their **view-if** condition is false. A choice can remain visible but disabled because its **choose-if** fails. Subtitles often explain resource gains, costs, or warnings, but not every hidden state effect is disclosed.

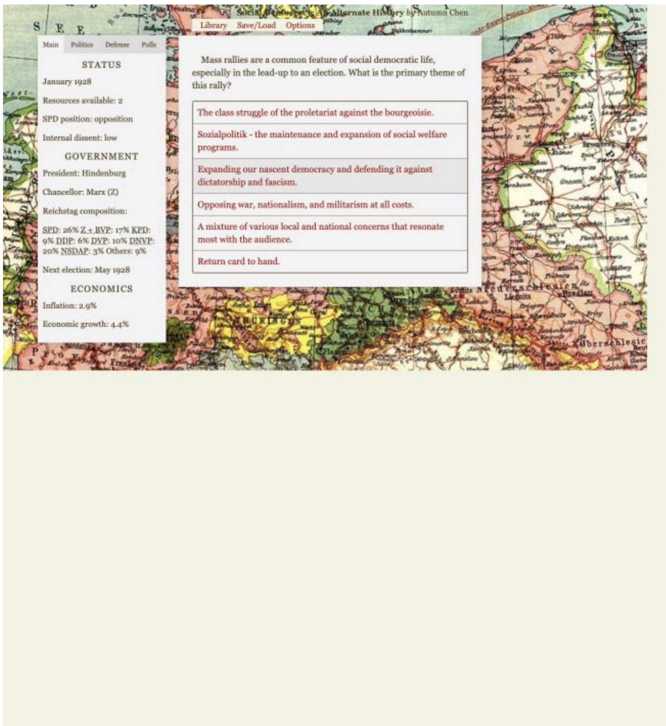


Figure 6. A normal card presents several political messages and a return option; the status panel remains visible for context.

Parliament and graphs

The Library's parliament graphic is an approximate visual representation of party result percentages. Election history records election results; party support history records monthly normalized support; economic history records inflation and unemployment. At the beginning of a game the history charts are mostly empty.

Important hidden state

The player normally cannot see:

- raw class-party preference weights;
- most cooldown numbers;
- exact coup and capital-strike progress;
- many event flags and prerequisites;
- detailed coalition formulas and resets;
- derived combat-power values;
- every ministry goal and achievement predicate;
- scene visit counts and event priority.

Where comprehension is difficult

1. Difficulty changes hidden political values without a complete preview.
2. Qdisplay labels can conceal proximity to a numeric threshold.
3. Raw support changes are difficult to translate into national vote effects.
4. Several government flags describe one conceptual coalition.
5. The same choice can affect support, factions, relationships, budget, and event pressure without a consolidated consequences view.
6. The initial start screen shows a zero-filled status panel before state is initialized.
7. The parliament looks exact even though it is based on an approximate percentage-to-seat rendering.
8. Historical mode hides polls and disables saves, changing both information and risk.

These are observations about clarity, not requests to change the interface.

Technical reference: **source/scenes/status.scene.dry**, all eight files under **source/qdisplays/**, **source/scenes/library.scene.dry**, **out/html/index.html**, and **out/html/game.js**.

13. How the browser game is assembled

DendryNexus in one paragraph

DendryNexus is the project's story language, compiler, and browser game engine. It lets the author describe pages, choices, conditions, state changes, and routes in text files instead of writing the entire interface from scratch. JavaScript is embedded only where loops or more complicated calculations are needed.

The important folders

Location	Plain-language role	Editing rule
source/info.dry	Game title, author, and identity metadata.	Source input.
source/scenes/	Narrative, cards, events, choices, calculations, and routing.	Edit here for game content/logic.
source/qdisplays/	Numeric-to-text labels used by the interface.	Edit here for display bands/wording.
assets/img/	Source image assets copied into the web build.	Preserve as source assets.
out/game.json	Compiled machine-readable game.	Generated; do not edit manually.
out/html/	Deployable browser game and customized runtime/interface files.	Mostly generated; selected tracked files are customized.

Scenes and qualities

A **scene** is a page or step in the experience. A file can contain a main scene and many named subscenes. A choice routes from one scene to another. Conditions decide whether a scene or choice is available.

A **quality** is a state variable: a named piece of memory such as the year, resources, dissent, unemployment, or whether an event has occurred. In embedded JavaScript, qualities live in an object named **Q**. The browser saves that state so the player can continue later.

From source to browser

```
source/info.dry + source/scenes/ + source/qdisplays/
              |
              | npm run build
              v
         out/game.json
              +
     out/html/ browser runtime
              +
      copied D3 and assets/img/
              |
              v
       playable browser game
```

npm run build runs DendryNexus, then copies the local D3 library and source images into **out/html/**. **npm run serve** starts a simple local web server for the built output. The browser loads **out/game.json**, creates the interface, maintains the hand and scene history, saves state, and calls D3 for charts.

The build proves that files compile. It does not prove that a route is reachable, a threshold is balanced, an old save is compatible, or a complex ending is correct.

Scale of the current source

The repository contains 167 source files: 158 scene files, eight qdisplays, and one metadata file. Those scene files define 1,117 source-authored scene nodes (158 top-level scenes and 959 subscenes). The compiled game contains five additional engine routing scenes. Static inspection identifies 989 literal or concretely constructed quality keys, although many are display helpers, candidate/timer families, or route-specific flags rather than independent headline mechanics.

For the technical detail behind these counts, see **MECHANICS_MAP.md** and **STATE_VARIABLES.md**.

14. Guidance for a future adaptation

This section classifies implementation patterns. It does not propose Polish history, institutions, parties, people, dates, or equivalents.

Probably reusable as general game systems

These are engine-level patterns that can support many political games:

- scene-and-choice narrative flow;
- card, deck, hand, and pinned-card interaction;
- action-driven monthly time;
- cooldown timers;
- tagged event eligibility and seen flags;
- separate source and generated output;
- qdisplays for player-friendly labels;
- save/load and chart-history concepts;
- a status panel alongside the current narrative.

Even these require interface and usability decisions. Their historical content is not automatically reusable.

Polish adaptation: TBD — user historical research and design decision required.

Reusable but requiring new data and balancing

The following mechanics are general enough to reuse in principle, but their lists, numbers, effects, thresholds, and feedback require fresh evidence and design:

- social-group support and vote normalization;
- election scheduling and result storage;
- coalition arithmetic and stability;
- internal factions and weighted dissent;
- relationships with other parties;
- adviser rosters and shared cooldowns;
- ministries as action gates;
- abstract party resources and government budget;

- economic indicators and policy stages;
- political organizations, loyalty, and escalation;
- achievements and multi-part ending summaries.

Polish adaptation: TBD — user historical research and design decision required.

Closely tied to the German baseline and requiring redesign

These systems embed German names, institutions, laws, organizations, or event chronology directly into variables and routes:

- SPD, KPD, Center/BVP, DDP/DStP, DVP, DNVP, NSDAP, SAPD, and “other” party

structure;

- Reichstag coalition formulas and the current approximate seat display;
- president/chancellor powers and the no-confidence/emergency-government paths;
- Prussian government and police as a separate political layer;
- Reichsbanner, Iron Front, SA, RFB, Stahlhelm, and Reichswehr systems;
- named leaders, advisers, presidents, ministers, and candidates;
- the 1928-1934 event calendar and election cycle;
- crisis programs, reparations, foreign-policy actors, and named agreements;
- current victory, defeat, and achievement conditions.

These cannot be treated as equivalent to Polish institutions merely because a similar English label exists.

Polish adaptation: TBD — user historical research and design decision required.

Unclear and requiring a design decision

- Should time remain one major action per month?
- Should the player draw random actions or choose directly from a menu?
- Should party resources and government budget remain abstract?
- Should elections use approximate percentages or an exact seat system?
- How much hidden state should the interface expose?
- Should a no-save/no-polls historical mode remain?
- Should advisers and ministries remain separate unlock layers?
- Should political violence use abstract power multiplication?
- Should old German saves or mods remain compatible with a future adaptation?
- Should outcomes remain a portfolio or become a clearer victory structure?

Polish adaptation: TBD — user historical research and design decision required.

15. Appendices

Appendix A: plain-language glossary

Term	Meaning
Action	A major party or government decision that normally causes one month to pass.
Card	One playable issue or activity, implemented as a Dendry scene.
Choice	A response inside a scene; it can change state and route to another scene.
Cooldown / timer	A month counter that temporarily prevents repeating a card or event.
Deck	A category that draws from a tagged group of currently eligible cards.
DendryNexus	The story language, compiler, and browser engine used by the game.
D3	The local JavaScript visualization library used for parliament and history charts.
Event flag	A stored yes/no or phase value recording that something happened or became possible.
Faction dissent	Dissatisfaction within one SPD faction; weighted into overall dissent.
Generated output	Files created by the build, especially **out/game.json** and much of **out/html/**.
Hand	The small set of drawn action cards currently available to play.
Leverage	Election-derived bargaining capacity used to claim ministries.
Normalization	Converting raw preference weights into shares that add to 100 percent.
Pinned card	A persistent adviser or control that stays available outside the normal draw cycle.
Quality / state variable	A named piece of persistent game memory, such as **resources** or **year**.
Qdisplay	A table that turns a numeric value into a readable word or month name.
Raw support	A hidden class-party preference weight before normalization; not itself a poll percentage.
Scene	A page or logical step containing text, choices, conditions, and state changes.
Tag	A label grouping scenes, such as party actions, government actions, advisers, events, or endings.
Visit count	Dendry's record of how often a scene has been entered, used to enforce limits.

Appendix B: one-page gameplay loop

Start

1. Start game initializes the complete state.
2. Choose easy, normal, hard, or historical mode.
3. Read the 1928 introduction and enter the main hand.

Each month

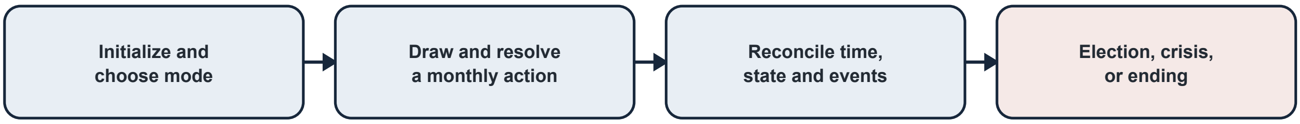
1. Review Main, Politics, Defense, and Polls tabs.
2. Draw from Party Affairs or, when available, Government Affairs.
3. Keep the drawn card in the hand or open it.
4. Choose an enabled response.
5. Pay resources/budget or accept political consequences.
6. Update support, factions, relationships, organizations, policies, or flags.
7. Mark the monthly action and set the card cooldown.
8. Return through the root scene to monthly reconciliation.
9. Normalize demographic voting and faction strength.
10. Advance month/year and reduce timers.
11. Record support/economic history and apply economic feedback.
12. Check scheduled and conditional events.
13. Resolve an event, election, government crisis, or terminal route if due.
14. Return to the changed main hand.

At elections

1. Recalculate vote shares.
2. Apply threshold and ban rules.
3. Save parliamentary results and changes.
4. Calculate coalition totals.
5. Choose government, opposition, toleration, or another available path.
6. Use leverage to negotiate ministries.
7. Continue with a new government state and future election date.

At the end

1. A terminal event or campaign endpoint reaches **game_over**.
2. The game evaluates political, military, economic, policy, and leadership outcomes.
3. Eligible ending summaries and achievements are shown.



Appendix C: major-mechanics reference

Mechanic	What the player manages	Main downstream effects	Key evidence
Cards and hand	Which available issue to draw and play	Time, opportunity, randomness	**source/scenes/main.scene.dry**
Resources	Party spending and fundraising	Campaigns, media, advisers, organizations	Party Affairs scenes
Support	Appeal among six modeled social groups	Vote shares and elections	**post_event**, **election_algorithm**
Elections	Thresholds, results, coalition arithmetic	Government, leverage, ministries	**events/election_1928.scene.dry**
Coalitions	Partners, stability, confidence	Government survival and policy access	Coalition/government event scenes
Factions	Strength and dissent of five SPD blocs	Support effectiveness, splits, leadership	**post_event**, **party_disunity**
Relationships	Cooperation with other parties	Coalitions, votes, candidates	**inter_party_relationships**
Advisers	Active specialist roster and cooldown	Shortcuts/modifiers across systems	**advisors/**, **shuffle_leadership**
Ministries	Offices claimed with leverage	Government card access and goals	Election and Government Affairs scenes
Economy	Inflation, unemployment, growth, policy stages	Support, budget, crisis, endings	**post_event**, economic-policy scenes
Finance	Taxes, tariffs, budget	Inflation, growth, resistance, policy capacity	**fiscal_policy**
Organizations	Party/media/defense investment	Support, militancy, violence capacity	Party Affairs organization scenes
Institutions	Police/military loyalty and constitutional rules	Coup, civil war, government survival	Government Affairs and event scenes
International	Directional relationships, agreements, aid	Events, economy, factions, endings	Foreign/international scenes
Endings	Consequences accumulated across the campaign	Final narrative and achievements	**source/scenes/game_over.scene.dry**
Saves/mods	Session continuity and alternate data	Compatibility and runtime trust	**out/html/game.js**, **mod_loader.js**

Appendix D: high-level source-file map

```
source/
|-- info.dry                    game metadata
|-- qdisplays/                  numeric values translated into words
`-- scenes/
    |-- root.scene.dry              initialization and difficulty
    |-- main.scene.dry              decks, hand and pinned cards
    |-- post_event.scene.dry        monthly reconciliation and event check
    |-- election_algorithm.scene.dry support-to-vote calculation
    |-- events/                     scheduled, conditional and election events
    |-- party_affairs/              party action cards
    |-- government_affairs/         policy and ministry action cards
    |-- advisors/                   pinned adviser actions
    |-- status.scene.dry            persistent information panels
    |-- library.scene.dry           in-game reference and D3 charts
    |-- events/civil_war.scene.dry  derived power and conflict outcomes
    `-- game_over.scene.dry         achievements and ending summaries

assets/img/                     source image assets
out/game.json                   generated compiled game
out/html/                       deployable browser game
```

Appendix E: unclear, inconsistent, or potentially broken behavior

The following are audit findings, not instructions to “clean up” the source:

1. **DNVP_relation**/**NSDAP_relation** are initialized with uppercase prefixes, while later code uses lowercase **dnvp_relation**/**nsdap_relation**.
2. **unemployed** is the main economic value, but some conditions reference **unemployment**.
3. **advisor_action_time** appears alongside the active **advisor_action_timer** convention.
4. **streseman_dead** and **stresemann_dead**, **reformists_resign** and **reformists_resigned**, and several singular/plural names coexist.
5. Some event flags and timers are read without explicit root initialization and rely on absent-as-false behavior or route order.
6. A zero total in support or faction normalization has no clearly confirmed guard.
7. The exact behavior when several events have equal eligibility/priority is unclear.
8. The **use_decimals** election option is marked TODO.
9. The parliament display is approximate rather than a confirmed exact seat allocator.
10. Government identity is spread across many flags whose complete mutual exclusivity has not been runtime-tested.
11. Strength, militancy, loyalty, and power use mixed scales.
12. Some initialized quality-of-life fields are explicitly described as unused.
13. The initial pre-game interface displays zero-filled status before state initialization.
14. Save migration/versioning behavior is not documented.
15. Remote mod loading, malformed data, CORS, and trust boundaries are untested.
16. Mobile layout, keyboard navigation, and screen-reader behavior require dedicated interface testing.

For each item: **UNCLEAR — requires code investigation or runtime testing.**

Appendix F: deeper references

- **MECHANICS_MAP.md** contains the detailed system contracts, dependencies,

thresholds, extension points, and source references.

- **STATE_VARIABLES.md** contains categorized state contracts and the complete

expanded 989-key inventory.

- **PLAN.md** is the user-owned decision worksheet for the future adaptation.
- **HISTORICAL_SOURCES.md** is the empty evidence register for user research.

No historical equivalence should be approved from this overview alone.

Polish adaptation: TBD — user historical research and design decision required.